NPI illusions in the L2 English of Czech and Slovak speakers: A pilot study

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NPI ILLUSIONS

- **Negative polarity items** (NPIs) are generally licensed within "negative-like" environments such as within the scope of a downward-entailing operator such as a **negative quantifier** or **sentential negation**:

1) In this class, **no** student has **ever** got an A.
2) In this class, the student **hasn't ever** got an A.
3) *In this class, the student has **ever** got an A.

- Unlicensed **negative polarity items** (NPIs) give rise to **grammaticality illusions** only when a certain type of intervening illusory licensor is present:

4) *The student who **no** teacher likes has **ever** got an A.
5) *The student who the teacher **doesn't** like has **ever** got an A.

- NPI illusions are **highly selective** when it comes to the **type of licensor:**
  - Illusions occur with **negative quantifiers** (1) but not with **sentential negation** (2)
- This is argued to be consistent with the **active scope, scalar theories** and **feature percolation accounts** (under auxiliary assumptions) but not the **cue-based retrieval theory**

Ladusaw, (1992); Drenhaus et al. (2005); Vasishth et al. (2008); Parker & Philips (2016); Orth et al. (2021); Muller (2022); Schwab (2022); Eberhard et al. (2005)

NPIS IN L2 ENGLISH

- Acquiring the licensing conditions on NPIs in L2 English is a learnability issue
- Unlicensed NPI *any* more readily rejected by L2 speakers in structures involving licensing from sentential negation than from negative implicature
- L2 speakers are particularly sensitive to the **presence of overt negation**

6) *I've heard **any** news about the campaign.
7) The teacher did **not** set **any** homework.
8) *Lucy probably bought **anything** last week.
9) James hardly ate **anything** at the party.

- Input effects override L1-specific issues
- L1 Czech: **sentential negation gives rise to NPI illusions**
- This is argued to be due to negation in Czech sitting structurally higher in a special NegP projection compared to English where it is low
- **It is plausible that sentential negation** gives rise to **NPIs illusions in the L2 English of L1 Czech and L1 Slovak speakers**

Gil et al. (2019); Lacina & Dočekal (2026); Marsden et al. (2018); Rankin & Wagner (2023); Zeilstra (2008; 2022)

1) DO NPI ILLUSIONS ARISE IN L2 ENGLISH?
2) IS THE VULNERABILITY TO ILLUSIONS IN L2 ENGLISH MODULATED BY PROFICIENCY?

PILOT EXPERIMENT

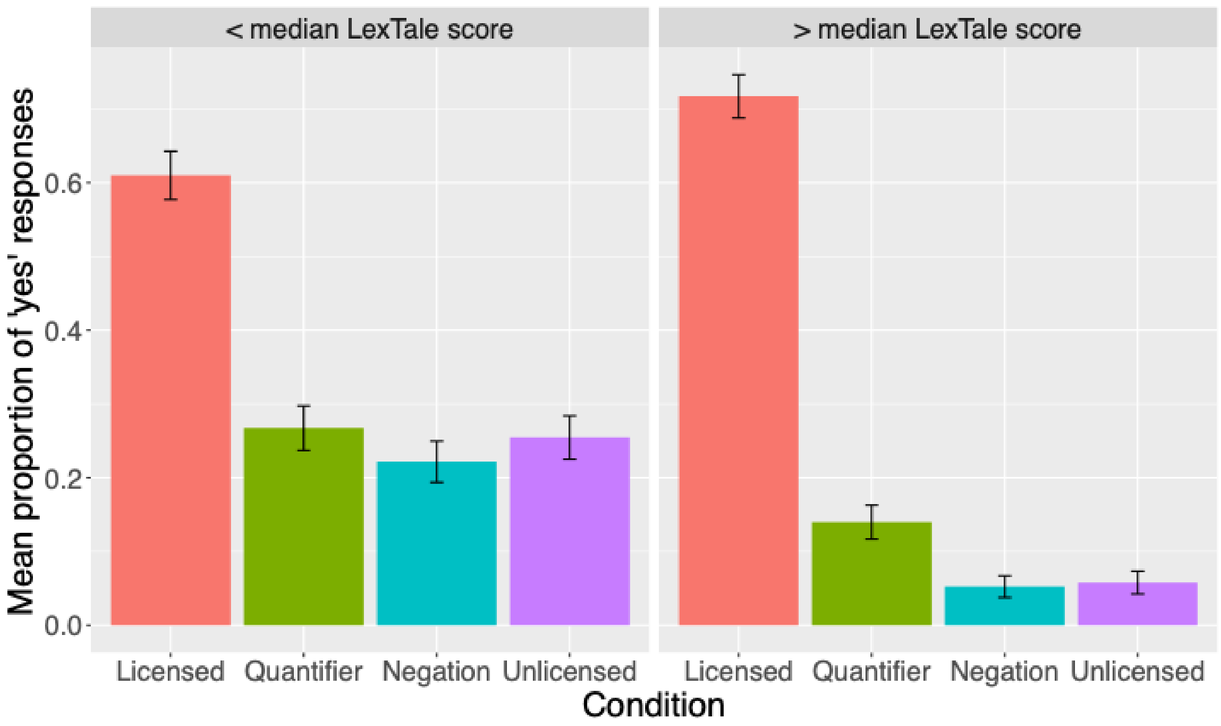
- Web-based platform PCIbex
- 53 L1 Czech or L1 Slovak L2 English participants (after exclusions):
  - I. LexTale task (lexical decision) to gauge L2 English proficiency
  - II. Binary speeded acceptability judgement task in their L2 English

CONDITION	ITEMS = 36, FILLERS = 72, RSVP AT 350MS
Licensed	No authors that the critics recommended have **ever** received praise for a best-selling novel.
Quantifier	The authors that no critics recommended have **ever** received praise for a best-selling novel.
Negation	The authors that the critics did not recommend have **ever** received praise for a best-selling novel.
Unlicensed	The authors that the critics recommended have **ever** received praise for a best-selling novel.

Items based on Exp1 of Muller (2022) and edited slightly to aid L2 comprehension

RESULTS

	MIN.	MAX.	MEDIAN	MEAN	ST.DEV.
LEXTALE	48.75	97.50	87.50	84.64	11.10



FIXED EFFECTS (TREATMENT)	BETA	ST.E.	Z-VALUE	P-VALUE
Intercept (Unlicensed, Lower median)	-2.2658	0.5593	-4.051	<0.001***
Negation	-0.1443	0.3288	-0.429	0.66072
Quantifier	0.7856	0.3276	2.108	**0.03499***
Licensed	2.8720	0.5310	5.409	**<0.001*****
Upper median	-2.8655	0.8828	-3.246	**0.00117****
Negation : Upper median	0.5519	0.6463	0.854	0.39315
Quantifier : Upper median	1.8413	0.6721	2.740	**0.00615****
Licensed : Upper median	3.4808	0.8535	4.078	**<0.001*****

DISCUSSION

- **grammaticality illusions observed with the NPI *ever*** with L1 Czech and L1 Slovak L2 English speakers **only with negative quantifiers,** unlike in their L1 Czech where negation causes illusions
- **Lower proficiency** L2 speakers showed **no illusions**, no effect of sentential negation
- The pattern is the mirror image of agreement attraction in L1 Czech L2 English where L1 Czech comprehenders show very little vulnerability in their native language, but are highly susceptible to attraction illusions in their L2 English

Chromý et al., (2023; 2025); Lacina et al., (2025)

TAKEAWAYS & FOLLOW-UPS

- NPI ILLUSIONS OCCUR IN THE L2 ENGLISH OF L1 CZECH AND L1 SLOVAK SPEAKERS WITH ONLY NEGATIVE QUANTIFIERS, NOT NEGATION
- MORE PROFICIENT L2 SPEAKERS SHOW LARGER ILLUSION EFFECTS
- REPLICATION WITH A LARGER SAMPLE AND WITH L1 GERMAN SPEAKERS
- ARE L2 ILLUSIONS RELATED TO ACCEPTANCE OF NPIS IN SUBJECT POSITION AND NEGATIVE CONCORD IN L2 ENGLISH?

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